

on, and gratitude for our contributions and experiences, we are more likely to feel at ease and more likely to feel satisfied.

I (Jill) have had times of feeling defeated about the way my life has panned out, especially in terms of finances. The zeal in my twenties for social justice causes but complete lack of value for earning money caught up with me in my thirties. Using only the metric of finances, I was not doing nearly as well as my peers. My social work education and career left me with debt, zero savings, no medical care, and certainly no retirement investment accounts. In many ways, it had me feeling “less than” and even a bit silly for the choices I made in that crucial decade.

While commiserating all this with Jen, it wasn’t long before I also recalled the investments I made in myself and in others that are leaving me rich in a way money never will. I’ve taken part in beautiful, meaningful things over the past fifteen years. From helping at-risk teens graduate high school to supporting marginalized women during crucial times of their recovery to traveling internationally to provide critical care to those experiencing crisis, the people who let me be a part of their journey have provided immeasurably more to me than any amount of money in my checking account. So, while there’s not much to show for it in the bank, I can say now that I wouldn’t take any of it back.

Every choice we make will have an opportunity cost. There is no world where sacrifice, loss, or disappointment doesn’t follow us. I know now that if I had chosen a high-earning career path, there would have been difficulties associated with that too!

So, for you, where are you experiencing dissatisfaction with your stuff, status, or situation? What is within your control? What is outside your control?

In what ways is your degree of satisfaction linked to who and what you’re comparing yourself to? Is the standard you use for how well you think you are doing or how great your things are based on your peers? People on the internet? Even your former or previously hoped-for self?

The problem is that nothing is exactly as it seems. There’s always a fuller story. You don’t know the intricacies of what made “success” possible for that person or the difficulties they may be facing. Instead, focus on what your choices and life experiences produced in you. The lessons you learned and the areas you are most grateful for.